in branding Rio de Janeiro as a destination for tourists and foreign investors and transforming Rio de Janeiro into a 'global city'. In 1994, the municipality, private companies and business associations came together and created a Strategic Plan of Rio de Janeiro, which was approved without democratic channels of participation (Vainer 2000:106). In 1996 the city sent its first bid to host the Olympic Games and in 2009 it won the bid for the 2016 games (Mascarenhas, Curi et al. 2011). The Strategic Plan is steered by business demands and interests with the aim to make the city more 'attractive' on the international market (Braathen et al. 2013:9).

Business and business opportunities are essential foundations for the new city and the new urban planning. In business, efficient management relies on the ability to take advantage of opportunities faster than the competitors. In the view of strategic planning, the city itself should function as a company. Political control and bureaucracy, such as responding to the institutional rights and guidelines of the Constitution or the Master Plan, erode a city's capacity to take advantage of business opportunities and, consequently, come across as efficient and competitive (Vainer 2011:5). The hosting of mega-sports events intensifies these processes, as they demand flexibility in order to fulfil the requirements of FIFA or IOC.

In their critical assessment of the 2010 FIFA World Cup in South Africa, Bond et al. (2011) show that the results were dubious priorities, overspending, loss of sovereignty and human rights, and broken trickle-down promises. Mega-sports events bring in multinational corporate sponsors, for whom exclusive rights to the sport venues and other public spaces are demanded (Klauser 2011; Mascarenhas et al. 2012). As existing institutional frameworks are overruled to respond to the needs of international sponsors and private interests, the Olympic bid books become the *de facto* urban planning documents in host cities. The close cooperation between a municipality and private sector leaders has been depicted by David Harvey as an international trend of transformation of urban governance towards 'urban entrepreneurship' (Harvey 1989). Others have termed this new strategic planning either 'ad hoc urbanism' (Ascher 2001) or *cidade empresa* – 'company city' (Vainer 2011).

According to Vainer (2000), the overriding of institutional guidelines and the implementation of a neoliberal regime can only happen by unifying the city around a common project. In Rio, the Olympic Games have served as the pretext, and two elements have been instrumental in legitimising the transformation of Rio into a host city. On the one hand, the city's patriotism led to a profound sense of pride among the inhabitants at the prospect of hosting a global mega-event. On the other, there was a generalised sense of an urban crisis stemming